

DESERTS

About one-third of Earth's land surface is desert, receiving under 10 in (25 cm) of precipitation annually. Deserts can be hot, cold, or polar. The Sahara is the largest hot desert, lying under a vast area of sinking, warming air, meaning rainfall is rare. The Gobi is the largest cold

desert; hot in summer, cold in winter, it receives little precipitation because it lies in the rain shadow of the Himalayas. The world's biggest desert is polar—the Antarctic, where the air is too cold to hold much water vapor for rain or snow.

North America

The Colorado Plateau

Location Arizona, Utah, New Mexico, and Colorado, southwest U.S.

This high, arid plateau made up of sedimentary rock layers boasts some of the most spectacular scenery in the world. Ranging in elevation from 2,000 ft (600 m) at the base of the Grand Canyon, which has been cut by the Colorado River, to 12,700 ft (3,870 m) in the La Sal Mountains, it owes its character to remarkable geological stability. There are many deep canyons, flat-topped mesas, towering buttes, and natural rock arches within the plateau's 130,000-square-mile (337,000-square-km) expanse. The walls of the formations reveal rocks ranging in age from billions to just a few hundred years old.

Other deserts in North America

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Central and South America

La Guajira Desert

Location Guajira Peninsula, northeast Colombia

This arid zone of xerophytic (drought-resistant) plants lies in the rain shadow of the Serrania de Macuira, a range of low mountains at the eastern end of the Guajira Peninsula, which intercepts

the northeast trade winds. La Guajira is a land of thorny bushes, cacti, and other succulents. Large numbers of American flamingos breed at the Parque Natural los Flamencos, and limited-range bird species include the vermilion cardinal, white-whiskered spinetail, and chestnut piculet.

The Sechura Desert

Location Piura and Lambayeque provinces, northern Peru

Covering 73,350 square miles (190,000 square km) of low-lying coastal Peru, the Sechura Desert

extends up to 60 miles (100 km) inland to the secondary ridges of the Andes mountains. To the north, it transitions into tropical dry forest while to the south it becomes the Peruvian Coastal Desert. Rain falls for only a few days each year. It owes its aridity to the atmospheric subsidence caused by the upwelling of cold water offshore. However, during the 1998 El Niño event, much higher than usual rainfall inland swelled rivers flowing through the desert and flooded a large part of the region, creating, for a time, Peru's second largest lake in the Bayovar Depression.

▼ THE GLEN CANYON REGION OF THE COLORADO PLATEAU

